CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

PT ASSISTANT IN THE AI ERA

The hands that deliver the therapist's plan, patient after patient, all day long.

★ **TL;DR — Around $45K median with 6–12 months of training and a credential at the end. The catch: you execute someone else's plan of care — real clinical work, bounded scope.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

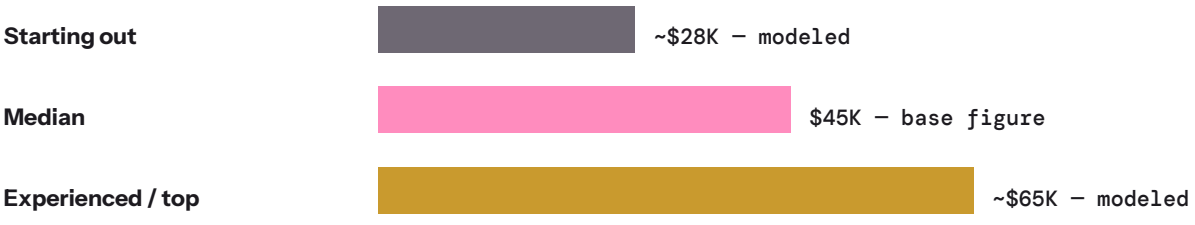
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$45K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- PTAs spend the longest continuous time with patients — the exercises, gait training and progress happen under your hands.
- The credential plus rehab demand keeps the role stable, while the pay ceiling is set by the supervising PT structure.
- AI handles documentation drafts and scheduling; it does not guard a stroke patient learning to walk again.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for PT Assistant is a ~$45K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A PT ASSISTANT ACTUALLY DO?

✓ Run exercise and mobility sessions from the PT's plan of care

- ✓ Teach patients their home exercises and check technique
- ✓ Use modalities: heat, ultrasound, electrical stimulation as directed
- ✓ Report progress and setbacks to the supervising PT and document visits

Think: the coach on the floor while the PT is the strategist — you run the drills that rebuild people.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI scribes, exercise-video libraries and remote check-in apps are automating follow-up and paperwork around the visits.	Hands-on guarding, cueing and motivating through painful repetitions. Reading when to push and when to back off is live human judgment.

⚠ **Scope is honest and bounded: you cannot evaluate patients or change the plan yourself. Frustration with that ceiling is the main reason PTAs leave or bridge up.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Active, physical work — no desk sentence ✓ Patients' progress is visible and personal ✓ Clinics, hospitals, nursing homes and sports settings all hire	✗ Your body is the tool: lifting and demonstrating all day ✗ Productivity quotas squeeze session quality in many clinics ✗ Pay tops out without moving into a PT doctorate

Good fit? You love movement, coaching and repetition with people — and you're fine executing a plan rather than designing it.
Bad fit? You need autonomy over treatment decisions; that frustration will follow you daily.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — THE ACCREDITED PTA PROGRAM	DOOR B — CLINIC AIDE TO PTA
Apply to an accredited physical therapist assistant program (this site's band: 6–12 months) with clinical rotations built in. Graduation makes you eligible for the credential exam employers expect.	Start as a rehab aide or tech in a clinic, learn the floor, then enter the program with experience and references. Slower, but you earn while confirming the field is really for you.

Smart move: Train in outpatient ortho if you can — the exercise variety and patient volume build the broadest skill set and the best references.

Where you land after: PT assistant → senior/specialty PTA (ortho, neuro, sports) — or the bridge to a DPT when you want the plan-writing pen.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP ACCREDITED	CLEAR THE	ENROLL AND	BUILD HANDS-ON	PASS THE	TAKE THE

STEP 1 — Map accredited programs

FREE · TODAY

- List accredited PTA programs and their clinical sites.
- Check what credential the program prepares you for and its pass rates.

STEP 2 — Clear the prerequisites

FREE–LOW COST · WEEKS

- Anatomy basics and CPR/BLS certification are typical entry needs.
- Shadow a clinic for a day; aide experience strengthens applications.

STEP 3 — Enroll and start clinicals

6–12 MONTHS

- Therapeutic exercise, kinesiology basics, modalities — plus supervised rotations.
- Rotations are auditions: clinics hire students they already trust.

STEP 4 — Build hands-on volume

THROUGHOUT

- Log gait training, transfers and exercise progressions across patient types.
- Ask preceptors for the complex cases, not the easy schedule.

STEP 5 — Pass the credential exam

EXAM FEE · AFTER GRADUATION

- Sit the PTA credential exam as soon as you're eligible.
- Complete your state's credential or registration process.

STEP 6 — Take the first PTA job

JOB HUNT · 2–6 WEEKS

- Ask about caseload and supervision style in interviews.
- First year: become the assistant every PT requests by name.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

☐ Today: list accredited PTA programs and their start dates near you.

□ Days 1–30: apply to your top programs; get CPR/BLS certified.

□ Days 31–60: shadow or start aide shifts in a clinic; finish entry requirements.

□ Days 61–90: confirm your seat or waitlist position; brush up on anatomy.

□ Day 90: you're in the training pipeline with clinic time already on your record.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ HANDS ON. EVERY SINGLE DAY. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.